

situation improved somewhat with a move to better lodgings; young Gaetano, meanwhile, received a scholarship to attend choir school under Simon Mayr, the Bavarian-born maestro di cappella at Bergamo's cathedral and a prolific composer of opera.

## Road to success

Mayr's lessons set foundations for Donizetti's career. He arranged for his pupil to attend Bologna's Liceo Filarmonico Comunale and, after completion of his studies in 1817, for an opera commission in Venice. Mayr also promoted Donizetti's cause in Rome, which led, in 1821, to his first commission for a major opera house, the Teatro Argentina, where Rossini's *The Barber of Seville* had premiered five years earlier.

Domenico Barbaja, the impresario of Neapolitan theaters, struck by Donizetti's Roman debut, invited the young composer to produce operas for him in Naples. Donizetti's first hit with the Neapolitan public, *La zingara*, enchanted Vincenzo Bellini, a student at Naples' Royal College of Music. A flop at Milan's La Scala and failures in Palermo were followed by a run of successful and well-paid works for Naples, and commissions elsewhere. With this new-found financial security he married Virginia Vasselli in 1828.

**“Lucia di Lammermoor** has been  
**performed**, and kindly **permit me** to ... tell  
you the **truth**. It has ... **pleased** very much.”

GAETANO DONIZETTI, LETTER TO THE PUBLISHER  
GIOVANNI RICORDI, 1835